



and Arab states, such as Pakistan and Saudi Arabia. This was the beginning of a curious relationship between the US and Islam.

With the PDPA in power, US president Jimmy Carter and national security advisor Zbigniew Brzezinski authorized the covert funding and training of antigovernment forces. Military and intelligence services backed with Saudi Arabian finance and Pakistani logistical support, managed the training, equipping, and paying of

Soviet withdrawal

In May 1988, Afghanistan, Pakistan, the USSR, and the US signed agreements to end foreign intervention in Afghanistan, and the USSR began withdrawing its forces.

volunteers, the Mujahideen (Persian for “warriors”), who opposed the Marxists.

The Soviet presence in Afghanistan was increasing. Citing the 1978 Treaty of Friendship, allowing Soviet military intervention if requested (see BEFORE), the Soviets stormed into the capital city of Kabul on December 24, 1979. The



110,000–150,000 Soviet troops arriving in Afghanistan (assisted by 100,000 pro-communist Afghan troops) were met with Mujahideen resistance. Despite Russia’s superior weapons, the rebels frequently eluded them in the hostile mountainous terrain.

“We now have the opportunity of giving to the USSR its Vietnam War.”

ZBIGNIEW BRZEZINSKI, U.S. NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISER, JANUARY 18, 1978

Stalemate

The international response ranged from stern warnings to a boycott of the 1980 Moscow Olympics. The conflict settled into a stalemate, with Soviet and

government forces controlling the urban areas, while the rebels operated freely in the mountains. As the war progressed, the rebels improved their tactics and began using imported and captured weapons. Their leaders favored sabotage, such as blowing up government office buildings. On September 4, 1985, insurgents shot down a domestic plane as it took off from Kandahar airport, killing 52 people.

In February 1988, under increasing international pressure, Soviet President Gorbachev announced the withdrawal of troops, a task completed a year later.

The war left Afghanistan with severe political, economic, and ecological problems. Many had died or fled the country, and economic production was curtailed. The guerrilla forces that had triumphed were unable to unite, and Afghanistan was divided between regional warlords. These divisions set the stage for the rise of the Taliban later in the decade.

AFTER

Following Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan in 1989, the United States and its allies did little to rebuild the country, leaving a dangerous leadership vacuum.

THE WARLORDS

Mujahideen factions gained power, but ethnic fighting broke out, giving rise to **warlords**. Out of this chaos emerged the **Taliban**.

RISE OF THE TALIBAN

The Taliban, led by Mullah Omar, was a **political and religious force**, which was initially supported by US-backed Pakistan. After taking control of most of Afghanistan, it imposed a strict interpretation of **Islamic Sharia Law**. Girls’ schools were closed and women were barred from working. Following the **September 11 attacks 466–67** >>, the US launched a military campaign to destroy the **Al-Qaeda terrorist network** operating in Afghanistan, and with it the Taliban government.



HAMID KARZAI

THE WAR CONTINUES

In December 2001, major leaders from the Afghan opposition groups agreed to form a **democratic government**, and Hamid Karzai was elected president in 2004. The Taliban regrouped on the border with Pakistan and has, since 2006, mounted severe attacks on NATO forces based in Afghanistan. Karzai’s re-election in 2009, disputed by his political opponents, has done little to bring stability. By 2010, though the Taliban had yet to be defeated, the US and other NATO forces planned to withdraw.

